I had never read Hemingway, but I had heard of him, of course. I said, "No. How does he say it?"

He says, The sun rose the next morning/ "

I got it. From that day to this, I labored to make my style a spare one. I eschewed all ornamentation for its own sake, and if ever my style seems to depart from the starkly straightforward and simple, it is only to achieve humor.

11

On December 30, I was at the most crowded and successful Hydra Club meeting I ever attended. Almost everyone I knew was there, from friends as old as Fred Pohl to those as new as Hans Stefan Santesson.

Marty Greenberg was there and carried through on his promise. He had with him a contract, which I signed, and that meant that Gnome Press would do a collection of my robot stories. There I was, with my first book not yet officially published and with a second under contract and a third under option.

John Clark was there with his wife, Mildred, who was a formidable woman, large, rather plump. Clark's friends apparently did not like her. In order to see him without her, Fletcher Pratt had the idea of starting a stag organization, whose only function was to have monthly dinners to which Clark could be invited sans wife. It was to be called "The Trapdoor Spiders," since the notion was that the husbands would get into a hole and pull the trapdoor shut behind them as protection from Mrs. Clark.

The organization had already been in existence for some five years and was still flourishing.

Bradbury was there and already had a review clipping from The Retail Bookseller that praised Pebble in the Sky.

Harry Schwartz was there. He was a fellow Boys High student who had been in the class before me, and he was eventually to become a well-known writer for the New York Times in the field of economics and medicine. I remembered him only vaguely, but he remembered me quite well and seemed astonished that I had achieved anything but a ticket to the looney bin. I guess he didn't take the trouble to get past my effervescence.

Sam Merwin and Leo Margulies were there, and though Sam had laryngitis,